

the lower-order's rescue acts, coincided with a period when India opted for more result-oriented and spin-friendly pitches.

From averaging 119.8 at home against spinners in 2019, the top-six averages 49.13 in 2024, still an improvement on a dismal 25.9 from the previous year.

Moreover, the top six batters are over two times more susceptible to spin bowling in home Tests compared to 2019, when they lost a wicket every 160 balls, compared to 56 in 2023 and 76 in 2024.

However, the same period saw a drastic uptick in the ability of the lower-order to tackle spin, with its average against the tweakers rising from 19.60 in 2019 to 47.25 in 2022, before dipping again to 35.60 and 33.56 in 2023 and 2024, respectively.

Thus, in two of the last four years — 2022 and 2023 — the lower-order has fared better against spin than the top-six batters.

The importance of lower-order runs has also reflected in India's team selections, with Axar often pipping Kuldeep to the playing XI owing to his greater batting ability, or Jadeja being preferred over Ashwin in overseas Tests for similar reasons.

With India hamstrung by the lack of a genuine seam-bowling all-rounder, the team has relied on Shardul Thakur for the cushion of some extra runs in the lower order overseas despite his average of 19.47, batting largely at No. 8, not inspiring much confidence.

But new head coach Gautam Gambhir isn't losing sleep over trying to develop a fast-bowling all-rounder, which could also be an asset in increasingly pacer-friendly conditions at home.

"We've been talking about it since Kapil Dev that we don't have a fast-bowling all-rounder. If we don't have it, we don't have it," he had said ahead of the first Test against Bangladesh.

Gambhir, instead, found occasion to celebrate India's bevy of spin-bowling all-rounders, who fittingly repaid their coach's faith.

"We have to manage people like



Dip in form: Virat Kohli's batting average at No. 4 has dropped to 33.16 at home between 2020 and 2024.^{AP}

Jadeja, Axar and Ashwin, who's got five [six] Test hundreds. Washi [Washington Sundar] is there as well. So, we've got quality all-rounders... Tell me how many international sides have a spin bowling all-rounder? There aren't many. India's got that luxury," he added.

With India getting its long Test season underway with its top and middle-order in transition, Rohit Sharma and his men have a dependable fail-safe in Jadeja and Ashwin, and by extension, Axar. They would, however, do well to limit their dependence on that luxury and seek more accountability at the top as India's challenges will only mount in its bid for a third consecutive berth in the final of the World Test Championship.

Tests in India since 2020

Batting Pos.	Runs	Average	100s	50s	Contribution
1, 2, 3	3701	43.03	11	14	40.76 %
4, 5, 6	2954	34.34	05	17	32.53 %
7, 8, 9	2171	31.92	03	11	23.91 %

Tests in India (2016-19)

Batting Pos.	Runs	Average	100s	50s	Contribution
1, 2, 3	5951	55.61	20	31	43.64 %
4, 5, 6	5410	60.78	15	21	39.68 %
7, 8, 9	1975	30.85	03	15	14.48 %

Tests in India (Averages by batting position)

Since 2020		2016-2019	
Batting Position	Average	Batting Position	Average
1-2	44.44	1-2	55.29
3	39.96	3	56.28
4	29.80	4	82.06
5	33.86	5	44.90
6	40.15	6	53.88
7	38.47	7	27.84
8	36.78	8	39.55
9	20.0	9	25.55
10	12.93	10	09.11
11	4.18	11	22.33